

THE ALETHEION HEIST

A Hellenorian one-shot for five 4th-level characters — roughly four hours

An occult society has already bought your crew's way into the most guarded building in the capital. All you have to do is pick up what they paid for, walk into the empire's museum of official history, and steal the one exhibit the Arcane Academy sealed behind four rings of mirrored glass — on the only night it will ever be unguarded enough to try.

Setting	Hellarchon City (Helarchon / Aetherion), capital of Hellenoria — Museum Hill, Scholars' District
Patron	The Eclipsed Mirror — occult magical society dedicated to Hecate, via their broker Madame Trioditis
Target	The Kleis Mycarion, a Mycairan bronze-and-bone key under the Academy's Seal of the Fourth Mirror
The catch	The seal marks bare-skin thieves for Academy scrying — so a seal-breaker (the Lysikleis) was bought on the black market in advance, already paid for
Reward	1,500 gp total, 300 gp each (fair 1,000 gp rate + 50% hazard premium): 600 gp advance, 900 gp on delivery — or swap the 900 for two divinity-infused Drachmae. Crew keeps the Lysikleis if a charge remains.
Deadline	Tonight. At dawn the key is crated for the Academy deep-vaults, forever.

Background — What Is Actually True

Long before the empire, the warrior-kings of **Mycairos, the Kingdom of Bronze and Blood**, landed on these shores and bent them to their will. Their runes repeat one phrase scholars cannot close the book on: *“the gift beneath stone.”* Then their cities emptied in a single generation — storms that carried voices, shadows moving against the light — and nobody knows why.

Three years ago, an Academy dig under **Thalos Ridge** — the ridge where archaeologists keep finding mass graves the official founding story says cannot exist — broke into a Mycairan under-citadel. Among the bronze was a key: forearm-long, bronze wound around bone, warm, with something like a heartbeat. Two conservators who handled it began sleepwalking toward the ridge. The Academy sealed it inside the **Seal of the Fourth Mirror** and parked it in the one place nobody robs: the state museum.

The Eclipsed Mirror believes the key opens the gift beneath stone, and that the gift is a crossroads — a door of the kind their mistress keeps. They cannot move openly; the Academy knows their faces. So they bought a seal-breaker, paid in full, and now they need five deniable professionals. Tomorrow the museum unveils its Treaty of Myrianth anniversary exhibition; the morning after, the Kleis moves to the Academy deep-vaults. **Tonight is the only night.**

The doom behind the job: whatever emptied Mycairos was beneath stone the whole time. The Mirror thinks they are opening a door for their goddess. Doors open both ways.

Strong Start

Dusk in Aetherion is violet — not sunset-violet; something older. In the back room of a harbor taverna, a veiled widow lifts her veil just enough to show she isn't crying, and slides a heavy pouch across the table. “Six hundred now. Nine hundred when the museum's star exhibit is in my hand. Everything the job needs has already been bought — you'll simply be picking it up. My circle asks three things: don't kill anyone, don't be seen taking it, and don't — under any circumstances — touch the key with your skin.”

She names herself **Madame Trioditis**, answers exactly three questions honestly (she counts them on her fingers), and points the crew at the Night Agora: *beneath the Old Harbor, tonight, wear masks — ask the Locksmith's Chapel for the Lysikleis. It's already paid for.*

Act I — The Night Agora (the black market)

Once a moon, **the Obsidian Masquerade** — the secret society sworn to Dionysus — throws a masked revel in a sea-cave warehouse under the Old Harbor, and the revel *is* the market. The Tenebral Covenant fences here. So does worse.

- **The door.** A satyr in an obsidian goat-mask requires a mask and “**a truth for a mask**” — each guest speaks one true secret aloud (passive Insight 17 to catch lies; DC 15 Deception sells a trivial truth as a deep one). Refusers pay 25 gp or win a round of Dragon's Hoard. Give every player this beat.
- **The pickup.** The Locksmith's Chapel — a stall in a beached hull hung with ten thousand keys. **Old Kyros** (Tenebral Covenant) honors the purchase without argument and hands over the Lysikleis.
- **The complication.** **Phalaina**, a moth-masked Nightweaver Syndicate broker, claims a prior purchase order (a lie, DC 13 Insight) and offers **3,000 gp** — double the whole fee — to divert the item. Refused, she toasts them and tries to lift it (Sleight of Hand +7 vs. passive Perception). No bloodshed here: the Masquerade's satyr-wardens enforce the peace of the revel.
- **Kyros also sells:** museum gossip, two doses of drowsy wine (DC 13 Con, unconscious 1 hr — 50 gp each), a stolen conservator's badge (30 gp; advantage on one Deception inside the museum).

The Lysikleis (“the Loosening Key”)

Wondrous item, no attunement. A handleless key of Virellarion **memorysteel** — the metal that remembers its last shape. Pressed against a lock, glyph, or seal for 1 minute, it *learns* the shape. Expend 1 charge to open that lock or suppress that seal/glyph for 1 hour. **2 charges remain**; it does not recharge. It hums, very slightly, like it's thinking.

Act II — Casing the Aletheion

The Aletheion — from *al■theia*, “truth; literally un-forgetting” — the Imperial Mouseion of Helarchon. Every label has been through the censors, so the wags call it the **L■theion**, the House of Forgetting. It is the history of the city told in five rooms — the approved version.

Tonight's window: closed for re-labeling on the eve of the anniversary exhibition. Inside: a skeleton watch (Warden Dexios + 4 phylakes), the curator working late, and — the wrinkle — **Inquisitor Callixta Vireon** of the Truth-Flame with two templars, auditing the Sealed Annex until dawn.

Casing by daylight (museum open till dusk, 2 sp)

- DC 12 **Perception** — the four bronze hoplites stand in *different poses* than this morning.
- DC 13 **Investigation** — hair-thin silver thread in the case seams: alarm-ward (+2 Heat if tripped).
- DC 14 **History/Arcana** — the Seal is a *tattletale*: reaching through marks the thief for Academy scrying. This is why the Mirror bought the Lysikleis.
- **Warden Dexios** owes the Tenebral Covenant 90 gp of dice debt. 100 gp clears it: he “forgets” to relight the undercroft lanterns and misplaces the case-rod for one hour. He panics if anyone gets hurt.

Three ways in

Route	How it works
A — The Label Night (front, social)	Conservators, caterers, and Truth-Flame clerks use the service dock all night. Forged/stolen credentials: DC 13 Deception (DC 15 if a templar checks). Inside legitimately — but escorted; slipping away is a group Stealth DC 12.
B — The Rain-Cistern (below, wet)	Old aqueduct cistern under Museum Hill. Rusted grate (DC 15 Athletics or thieves' tools; loud = +1 Heat), 60 ft of chest-deep water (group Athletics DC 12), a drowned ward-glyph (DC 14 Perception to spot; DC 14 Arcana or the Lysikleis learns-and-suppresses it free; tripping it = +2 Heat, 3d6 thunder, DC 13 Con half). Emerges 40 ft from the vault stair.
C — The Skylight Walk (above, high)	Academy viaduct to the roof (DC 13 Athletics; 30-ft drop on a miss). Skylight frame opens DC 13 with tools; 60 ft of rope to the rotunda floor — between the four bronze hoplites. Group Stealth DC 13.

The Lantern Clock (Heat 0–6)

+1 Heat whenever the crew is loud, leaves a body-shaped absence, or fails a check that says so.

Heat	What happens
1	Dexios does an extra round; lanterns relit in dark rooms
2	Phylakes pair up; one watches the rotunda balcony
3	The four bronze hoplites step off their plinths and begin patrolling
4	Inquisitor Vireon emerges with her templars, lights the rotunda, starts interviewing — she wants arrests, not corpses
5	A runner goes out; 6 city phylakes reach the portico in 10 minutes
6	Full lockdown: doors barred (DC 17), Academy custodians arrive early. Improvise a legend.

Act III — The Heist

The Bronze Vault

Down the roped-off stair, behind a bronze-faced door (Dexios's key, the case-rod, or DC 15 thieves' tools). The vault is Mycairan bronze floor to ceiling. Pressure plates tile the center aisle (DC 14 Perception to spot the seams; DC 12 Acrobatics along the wall-lip; a plate rings a deep bell, +2 Heat). At the center, on a basalt plinth: four counter-rotating rings of mirrored glass, and inside them, suspended in nothing, **the Kleis Mycarion**. In every ring the reflected room is slightly wrong.

Beating the Seal of the Fourth Mirror	Result
The Lysikleis (intended)	Press to the outer ring 1 minute, expend 1 charge — the rings unwind over 3 quiet rounds. No alarm, no mark.
Reaching through	3d8 psychic (DC 14 Int half) and the toucher is mirror-marked : an Academy scry-beacon for 7 days. A delayed catastrophe — they win tonight and are hunted tomorrow.
Brute ritual	DC 20 Arcana over 10 minutes; three failures = backlash as above.
Smashing the rings	Instant — every bell rings (+3 Heat) and the twist below triggers immediately.

The Twist — the bronze remembers

The moment the Seal is down and the Kleis leaves its plinth *by any method*, every Mycairan bronze in the building remembers what it was for. Verdigris tears run. The colossus head in the corner grinds upward on a body of assembled exhibit-pieces — the **Bronze Revenant of Mycarion** — and the four hoplites turn toward the vault. **This is an escape encounter, not a boss-kill**. The Revenant is slow (25 ft), bound to the museum grounds, and wants only the key: whoever carries it is its sole target. The fun is the running handoff while the building wakes up.

- **Escape routes:** the cistern (Revenant won't fit; hoplites follow), the skylight rope (it can't climb — it *can* throw plinths), the front doors (Heat permitting), or straight through the Sealed Annex while the Truth-Flame turns its fire on the walking bronze — tonight they hate heresy more than thieves.
- **The rival crew:** at the worst moment, a Tenebral Covenant trio under **Melaina** is mid-burglary in the Founders' Hall. Professionals: no killing, no loyalty to anyone in the building. Extra hands for a cut, a beautiful distraction, or the people who lock a door at exactly the wrong time. If the crew cleared Dexios's debt, Melaina owes them one favor — one door in Hellenoria, any city, unlocked.

Delivery

Trioditis is the **lamplighter** on Museum Hill's lower stair — and has been all night (DC 16 Insight at any earlier meeting to have clocked that the widow's shadow fell the wrong way; she is a changeling). She pays in full, honors the Drachmae swap, lets the crew keep the Lysikleis “as a reference from satisfied clients,” and asks one question she means: “*Did it whisper to any of you?*”

The Museum — Wings, Exhibits, Fence Values

Fence values are Tenebral Covenant prices. “Heat” is the aftermath cost of a famous piece going missing.

Rotunda of the Concord (ground)

The founding mosaic — settlers of every trade laying down tools together — under a domed skylight, watched by four bronze hoplite statues the staff re-pose every dawn and log as “cleaning.”

Founders' Hall (ground, west)

Exhibit	The label says	What's true	Fence / Heat
The Oath-Prow	Figurehead of the first settler ship	True — and three noble houses would pay to suppress the older alphabet carved on its back	400 gp / severe
The Thalos Stele	“Ceremonial ossuary marker”	A mass-grave stone from the Unity Wars the founding story says never happened	150 gp; 600 gp to a dissident scholar / moderate

Exhibit	The label says	What's true	Fence / Heat
Votive nets, mining lamps	Trades of the founders	True	40 gp / low

Hall of the Storm-Star (ground, east)

Exhibit	The label says	What's true	Fence / Heat
Astraphael's Half-Mantle	Worn at the unification; storm-scored	The scorch pattern is from the <i>inside</i>	800 gp / extreme — the city riots
Treaty of Myrianth (facsimile)	The peace	Carries one clause the public text lacks (Secret 8)	200 gp / high
The Silent Sail	Sailcloth of the victory fleet	Still damp. Always. Cut from a ship that never docked	300 gp to the right cult / high
The Broken Blade	“Shattered in the final duel”	A name has been chiseled off the plinth — Sandarion's	250 gp / high

Gallery of the Violet Dusk (upper)

Exhibit	The label says	What's true	Fence / Heat
Aetherglass panes (×6)	Vitrified sand from “the old harbor fire”	Aether-scarred glass from the event filed under Vault Record 7c; shows <i>yesterday's</i> sky	100 gp each / moderate
The Dusk Prisms (×3)	Academy optical instruments	Pointed at the Seal, the reflection shows a fifth ring that isn't there	75 gp each / low

The Sealed Annex (upper — Truth-Flame custody)

Proscribed manuscripts: Selenarion's original vellum with the Inquisitor's annotations and the dissident's margin-notes, the erased records of Iovanius Sandarion. Nothing here is on the contract; any single manuscript is 500+ gp to the right buyer, and taking one opens a permanent Truth-Flame file.

The Bronze Vault (undercroft — the target)

Rune tablets repeating “*the gift beneath stone*” (60 gp each ×4 / moderate), blood-ward bracelets (40 gp ×6 / low), the Weeping Bronze colossus head, and the **Kleis Mycarion** under the Seal.

The Kleis Mycarion

Forearm-long key of layered bronze wound around what is probably bone. Warm; a slow pulse, one beat per breath. Skin contact brings dreams of Thalos Ridge, and a DC 12 Wisdom save each dawn or the holder spends the day *knowing which direction the ridge is*. No listed fence value — there is exactly one buyer, and she already paid.

NPCs

Who	Look & manner	Motivation
Madame Trioditis — broker, the Eclipsed Mirror	Veiled widow / fishmonger / lamplighter — one changeling. Silver ring with a black-mirror disc; myrrh and rain. Speaks in threes; answers exactly 3 questions honestly per meeting.	Deliver the Kleis intact and untouched. The crew is a tool she'd prefer not to break.
Old Kyros — fence, Tenebral Covenant	A hull hung with ten thousand keys; hands like driftwood. Never says “stolen” — says “orphaned.”	The Covenant's credit is only as good as its deliveries. The Mirror paid, so the Mirror's crew collects.
Phalaina — broker, Nightweaver Syndicate	Grey moth-mask, grey gloves; laughs a half-second late.	Nyx's faithful want the Lysikleis — or to know exactly who has it and where it goes.
Warden Dexios — night warden	Watery eyes; keeps misplacing his warden's rod; 90 gp of Siege Breaker debt.	Keep his post, clear his debt, and above all: nobody gets hurt on his shift.
Curator Eupraxia — curator, ex-scribe of the Circles of Mirrors	Ink-stained cuffs; corrects grammar mid-crisis.	The exhibition must open. Secretly keeps Selenarion's uncensored draft labels in her desk (Secret 9).
Inquisitor Callixta Vireon — Truth-Flame, blood-heir to the Third Seat	Ash-grey vestments; carries a brand-iron like a holy symbol; two templars.	The labels will say what the Truth-Flame requires by dawn. Thieves are a nuisance; walking bronze is heresy.
Melaina — crew-leader, Tenebral Covenant	Soot-dark leathers; a whisper that carries; her two seconds never speak.	The Oath-Prow's gold, the exits, and never being owed less than she's owed.

Monsters & Stat Blocks

Creature	Core numbers	Unique move
Museum Phylax ×4 (+6 city at Heat 5) — <i>guard</i>	HP 11 · AC 16 · spear +3 (1d6+1). Goal: raise the alarm, protect staff.	Lantern flash — action: hiders within 30 ft must re-Stealth.
Bronze Hoplite ×4 — <i>animated armor</i>	HP 33 · AC 18 · 2 slams +4 (1d6+2). Patrol at Heat 3+; converge on the Kleis when the Seal falls.	Phalanx memory — +2 AC within 5 ft of another hoplite.
Inquisitor Callixta Vireon — <i>priest</i>	HP 38 · AC 13 (16 w/ shield of faith) · sacred flame 2d8 (DC 13 Dex), mace +2 (1d6). Wants arrests.	Truth-Flame brand — bonus action, DC 13 Wis or the target cannot hide from her for 10 min.
Truth-Flame Templar ×2 — <i>guard var.</i>	HP 22 · AC 16 · flame-tipped mace 1d6+1 plus 2 fire.	—
Phalaina — <i>spy</i>	HP 27 · AC 13 · 2 shortswords +4 (1d6+2), sneak attack +2d6.	Moth-step — bonus action: teleport 15 ft between areas of dim light.
Melaina & seconds ×3 — <i>spies</i>	As spy; Melaina HP 32, Stealth +7. Nonlethal professionals.	—
Bronze Revenant of Mycarion — <i>helmed horror, enlarged</i>	HP 90 · AC 19 · speed 25 ft, bound to museum grounds · 2 slams +6 (2d6+4). Head: AC 17, HP 25 — if the body drops while the head lives, it reassembles at 10 HP next turn. Targets only the key-carrier. Loot: arcanite-veined heart-ingot, 250 gp.	Remembers every blow — resistance to the last damage type taken until end of its next turn. Plinth-throw (recharge 5–6) — +5, 2d10, range 60 ft. Verdigris weep — start turn within 5 ft: DC 12 Con or poisoned 1 round.

Scaling: 4 players — two hoplites stay statues, Revenant HP 70. 6 players — six hoplites, Revenant HP 105 and plinth-throw recharges 4–6.

Secrets & Clues

- **1.** Madame Trioditis is a changeling — the widow, the fishmonger, and the lamplighter are one person, watching all night.
- **2.** The Mirror commissioned the Lysikleis a year ago, shaped specifically to learn Academy seals. This was always the plan.
- **3.** “Don't touch the key” isn't squeamishness: skin contact starts the Thalos Ridge dreams. The Mirror needs carriers, not converts.
- **4.** Dexios's dice debt is held by the Tenebral Covenant — which is how Melaina's crew got their floor plans.
- **5.** The undercroft is checked once a night, at midnight. The flooding ruined the lantern brackets and nobody fixed them.
- **6.** The rotunda hoplites have been changing pose for years; the staff log it as “cleaning.”
- **7.** The mass graves under Thalos Ridge and the Thalos Stele are the same story: the founding was a conquest, and the Kleis was dug from underneath the losers.
- **8.** The treaty facsimile's extra clause cedes “the stone beneath Thalos” to no signatory. Someone at Myrianth knew the ridge must belong to nobody.
- **9.** Curator Eupraxia keeps Selenarion's uncensored labels in her desk — leverage against the Truth-Flame, one drawer away.
- **10.** In every mirror-ring of the Seal the reflection is one instant behind — except the innermost, which is one instant ahead.

Treasure, Aftermath & Sequel Hooks

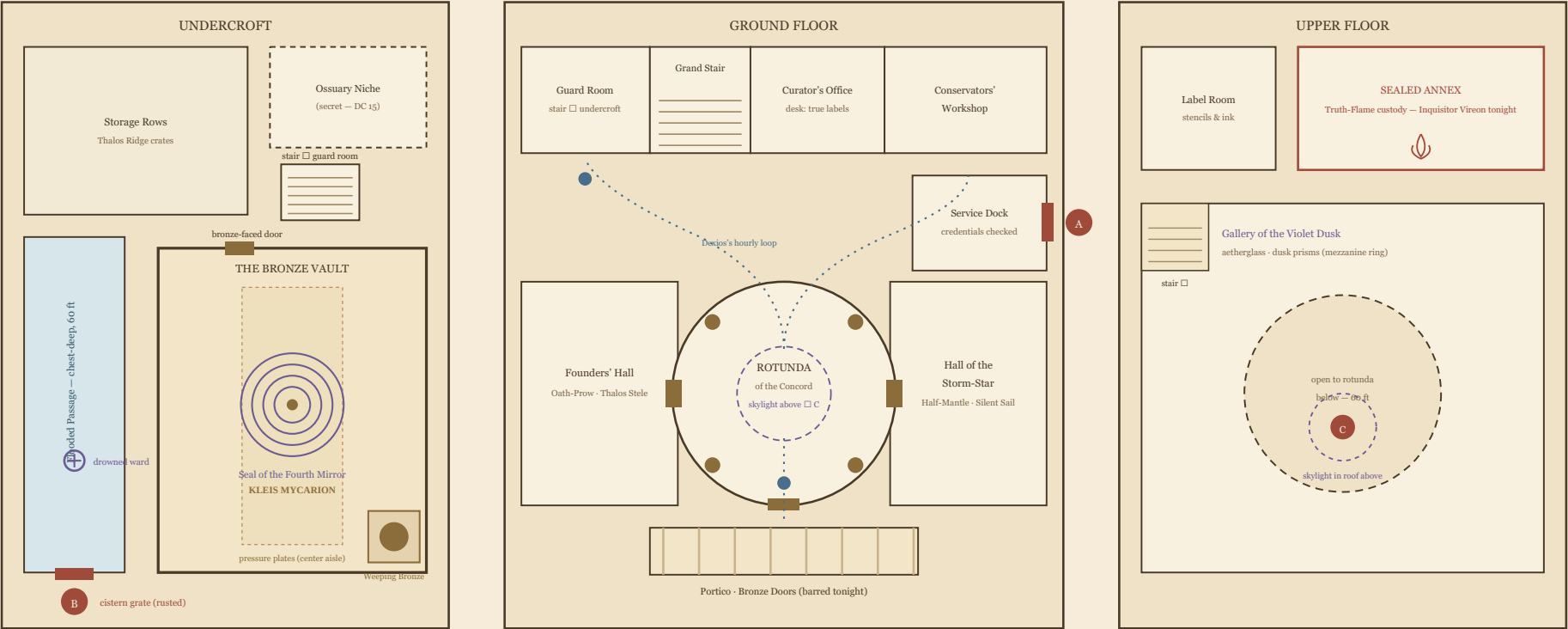
- **The job clean:** 1,500 gp, the Lysikleis, and a satisfied occult society that now considers the crew proven. Next contract: escort work to Thalos Ridge — and they'll even be honest about it. Mostly.
- **The key delivered:** within a season, the ridge. *The gift beneath stone* is a campaign, not an epilogue — and the bronzes of the city weep the day the door opens.
- **The key kept or diverted:** whoever holds it dreams of the ridge. The Mirror doesn't send letters; it sends the Crimson Pact. Phalaina's 3,000 gp offer stands. The Truth-Flame file grows either way.
- **The Revenant destroyed quietly:** the Academy pays a 200 gp “finder's honorarium” through the museum, no questions asked in a way that is itself a question.
- **Melaina's favor:** one door in Hellenoria, any city, unlocked. She means it literally.

Pregens note: Hellenorian-raised characters may take a benefit/drawback pair from the Hellenoria homebrew traits (Arcane Insight, Cultural Empathy, Philosopher's Insight).

The maps: the last four pages are the annotated DM schematic (entrances A/B/C, patrols, wards) followed by three player-safe battle maps on a 5-ft grid — ground floor, upper floor, undercroft — ready to show at the table or drop into a VTT.

THE ALETHEION

Imperial Mouseion of Helarchon — “the House of Un-forgetting” — Museum Hill, Scholars’ District

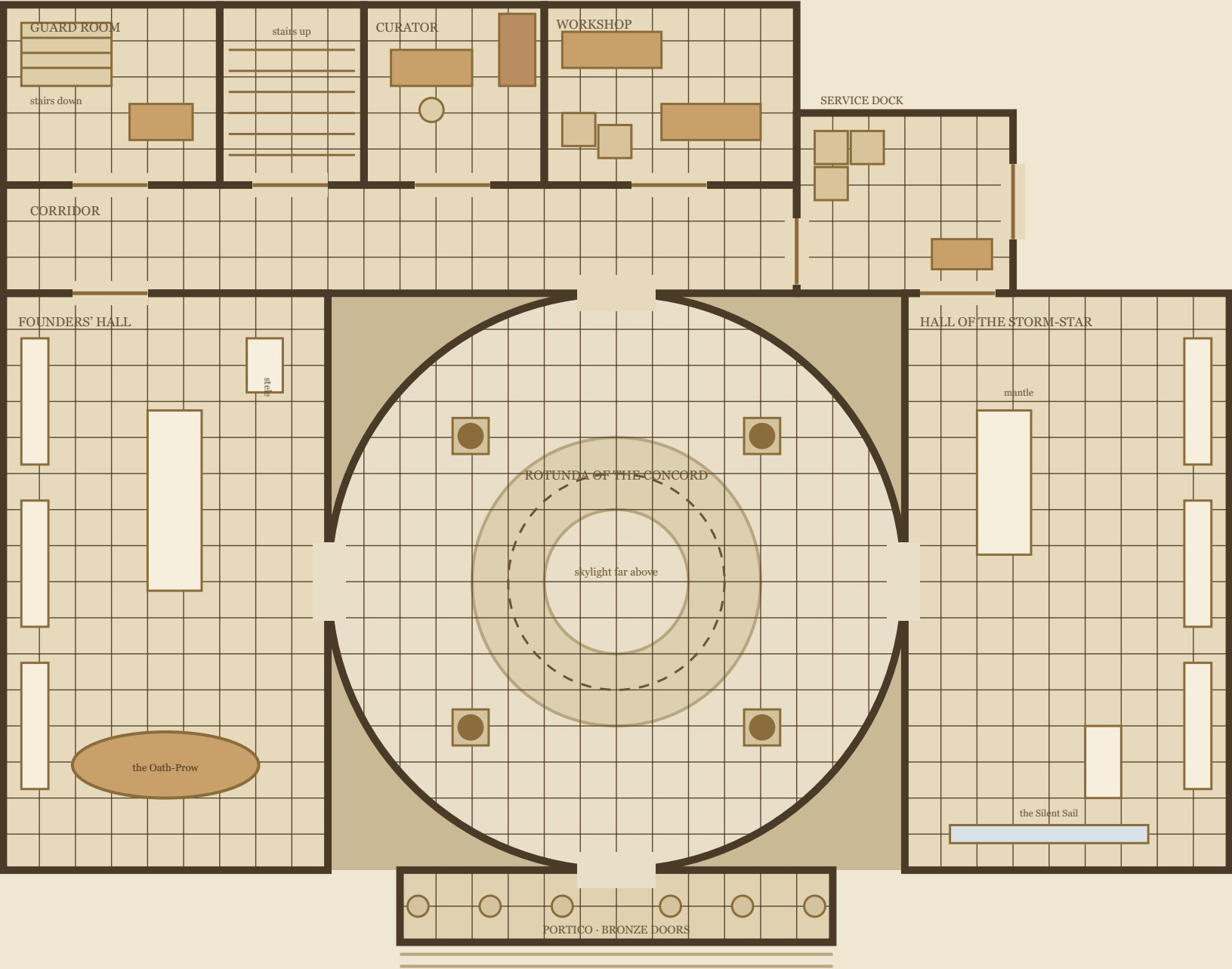


LEGEND

- A Service dock — forged/stolen credentials (Deception DC 13–15)
 - B Rain-cistern grate — flooded passage, drowned ward (Athletics/tools DC 15)
 - C Rooftop skylight — via Academy viaduct; 60 ft rope to rotunda floor
 - Bronze hoplite (animated at Heat 3+, or when the Seal falls)
 - Guard post · dashed blue line: patrol route (hourly)
 - Pressure plates — Perception DC 14, wall-lip Acrobatics DC 12
 - Arcane ward / seal — the Lysikleis learns it in 1 minute
 - Secret or concealed feature
- Rooms are 40–60 ft across; the rotunda is 80 ft wide. Undercroft sits below the west half.

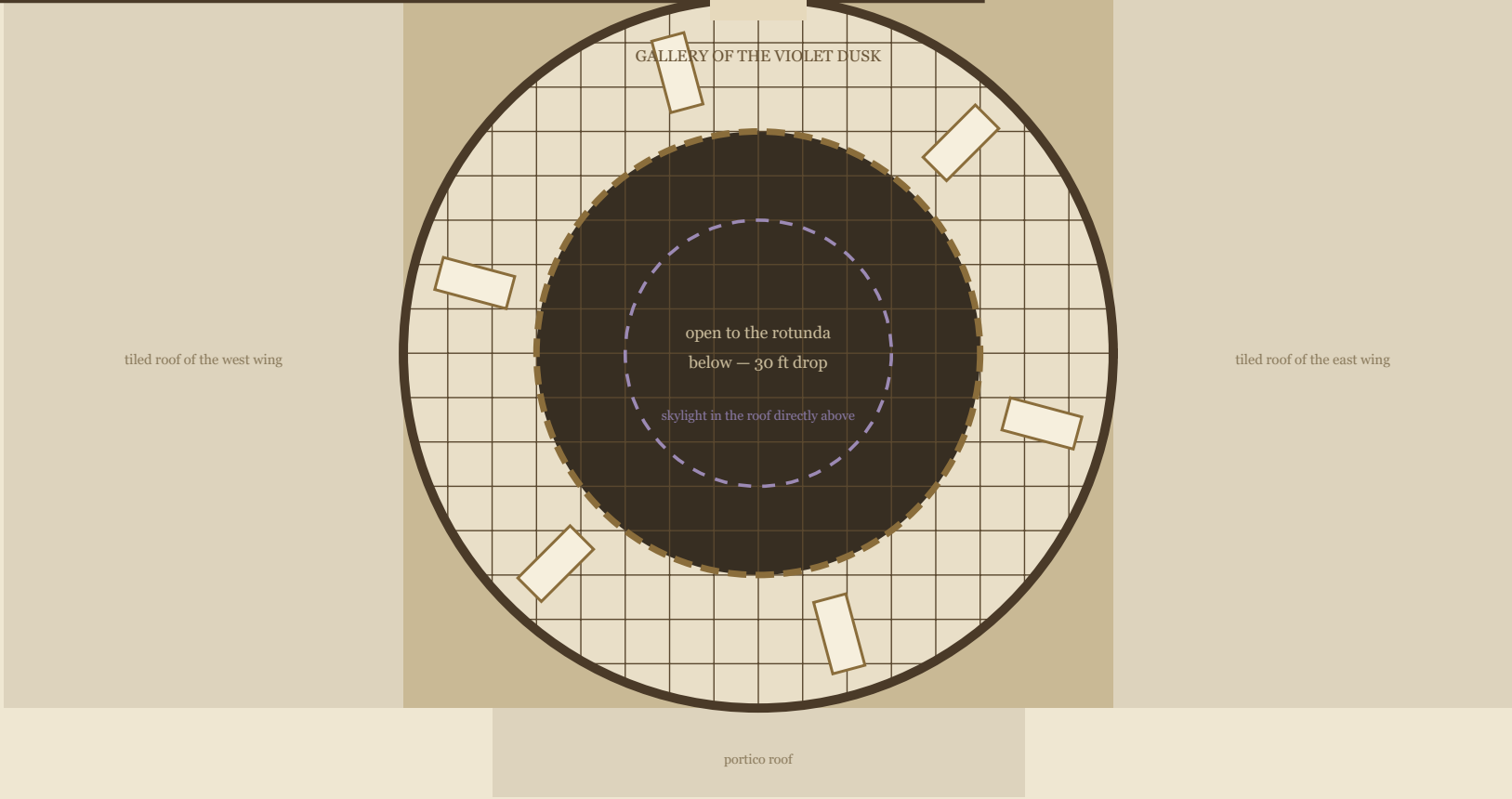
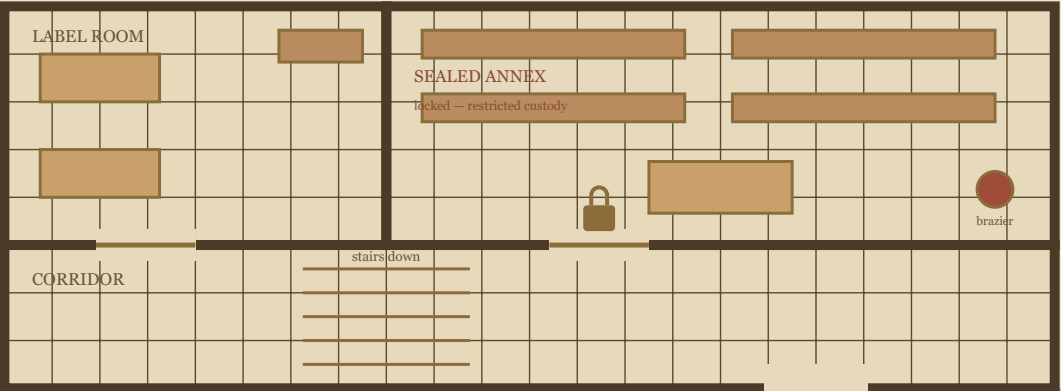
THE ALETHEION — GROUND FLOOR

1 square = 5 ft · battle map, player-safe



THE ALETHEION — UPPER FLOOR

1 square = 5 ft · battle map, player-safe



THE ALETHEION — UNDERCROFT

1 square = 5 ft · battle map, player-safe

